

| By Uday Mahurkar |

The Gujarat Government's extravagant plans to sell the state as a destination for Buddhist tourists have just got an unexpected boost. Archaeologists have excavated a Buddhist vihara (monastery) in Vadnagar, considered the crown jewel among historical sites in Gujarat. A votive stupa has also been discovered. They were built by devotees to pay their gratitude to Lord Buddha on fulfilment of their desires. Over the past five decades, many historical sites

have been excavated in this area but this is the first time that a Buddhist vihara has been unearthed. Gujarat director of archaeology Y.S. Rawat says, "In archaeological terms, we have discovered a gold mine since it proves what Hieun Tsang had written."

Tsang was the famous Chinese traveller and historian who in his travels in India from 629 to 645 A.D. had described many towns that he visited. One of them was Vadnagar, which archaeologists regard as one of the few Indian towns to have remained continuously inhabited for the past 2,200 years. It has lived through the Buddhist era, the Solanki era, the Sultanate and Mughal periods and Gaekwad rule. On Vadnagar, Tsang wrote there were 10 Buddhist viharas in the flourishing town and 1,000 monks lived there.

Chief Minister Narendra Modi, who is a native of Vadnagar and the force behind the drive to sell Gujarat as a Buddhist destination, is understandably upbeat. During a recent visit to the state, Sri Lankan Tourism Minister Milinda Moragoda promised that the country will look at Gujarat as a Buddhist tourist destination. Not just this, the monastery also received global recognition recently when known British expert Robin Conningham, who is engaged in research on the great Buddhist site in Anuradhapur in Sri Lanka, called it a significant discovery.

Till now, Gujarat's main Buddhist site has been Devnimori, which was excavated by noted archaeologist S.N. Chaudhary in 1959. Like in Sarnath and Sanchi, there are many stupas across India which have stone or brick structures containing the Buddha's relics in caskets buried inside stupas where they usually can't be seen. The Devnimori casket, believed to contain the



THE GRACEFULLY CARVED GATEWAY BELIEVED TO BE PART OF A GREAT TEMPLE COMPLEX BUILT BY SOLANKI RULERS

ashes of Lord Buddha, is one of the few which can be seen and touched. Vadnagar promises more, however. What Rawat and his team of four have discovered is a 16x16 m structure with a 7x7 m courtyard surrounded by a dozen cells in which monks

lived. The excavated artifacts are small in size but confirm that it was a Buddhist settlement. There is small plaque carved in stone which shows a monkey offering honey to Lord

Buddha, part of a famous tale depicted at many Buddhist sites. Then there is a disfigured head of the Buddha inscribed on a stone with the *prabhamandap* (aura) depicted around the head. A votive tablet showing the footprint of the Buddha has also been discovered.

Archaeologists also excavated what is called Northern Black Polished Ware. Associated with Buddhist settlements, some bear inscriptions in the Brahmi script saying, "Shakasya" (probably another name for Buddha who was also called Shakyamuni), "Devrisi" (another name for Buddha) and "Dhamma" (religion). Another important find was a finely sculpted head in the

